
ISO 100 | 24 mm / f-1.48 | 1/33s


ISO 800 | 4mm | f-1.48 | 1/25s


ISO 500 | 100mm | f-2.8 | 1/125s

have arrived long before generative AI became a tech obsession. Siri is still in beta, mind you, so it still occasionally misfires, but it's certainly more useful now than it ever was before – and will continue to improve (hopefully)

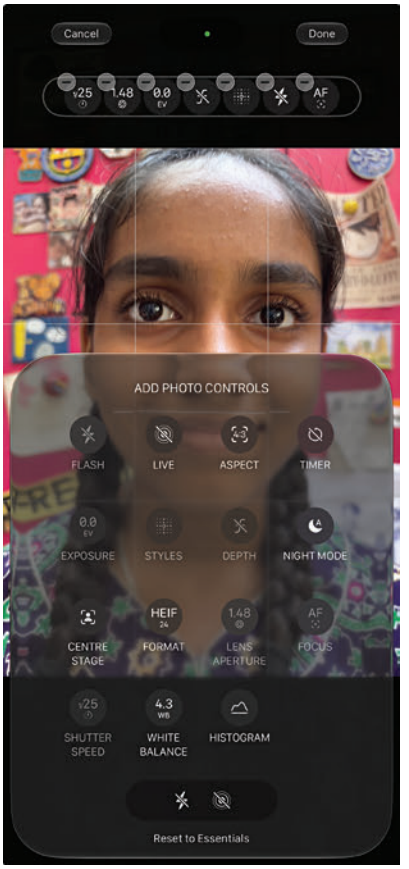
Gaming is fun on the iPhone 18 Pro Max as well, another key use case where the bigger screen size is justified. I enjoyed multiple sessions of Gear Club Stradale for racing action and Oceanhorn 3 for Zelda vibes, and a few other Indie titles, without any perceptible overheating of the iPhone 18 Pro Max – thanks to the improved vapour chamber's better heat dissipation.

The genuinely 18 Pro-specific magic anyone will care about is still about the camera. Pro controls in the Camera app, Apple Reference Image, the new Texture and Grain adjustments inside Photographic Styles, and that mechanical variable-aperture main camera. Those are the additions that make the hardware itself more interesting, rather than merely showing what iOS 27 can teach an older iPhone.

WHO IS THIS PHONE FOR?

There are still limits, however. The iPhone 18 Pro Max's Camera app hasn't quite reached the sophistication of a mirrorless-camera interface, and Apple still keeps certain granular controls – ISO being the obvious example – inside tools such as Final Cut Camera rather than exposing everything in its default photography interface. But that's almost beside the point.

For most people, the iPhone 18 Pro Max is simply too much iPhone. Too big, too expensive and packed with controls they will hardly touch. The regular iPhone – or even the "e" version – will make far more sense. And if you already own a 16 Pro or 17 Pro, there is little reason to rush out and replace it.



But I also feel that misses the point in a way. The iPhone 18 Pro Max feels like Apple finally deciding what "Pro" is supposed to mean. Not better selfies or another benchmark victory, but the ability to shoot, control, process, edit and deliver professional work from one device. Variable aperture, manual exposure tools, focus peaking, on-device AI and an A20 Pro powerful enough to keep that entire workflow local. This makes the iPhone 18 Pro Max from a very expensive smartphone into something closer to an all-in-one pocket production system.

I still find it too large for my liking. But for the first time, I also think the Pro Max has a convincing answer to the question: who is this phone for? Professionals.

– Jayesh Shinde

SPECIFICATIONS

SoC: A20 Pro | Memory: 12 GB | Storage: 256/512 GB, 1/2 TB | Display: 6.9-inch LTPO Super Retina XDR OLED | Refresh Rate: 120 Hz | Brightness: 3000 nits | Camera(Main): 48MP + 48MP + 48MP | Camera(Front): 18MP | Battery: 5567 mAh | IP Rating: IP68 | Weight: 249g

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